Mentors Before Trackers

Yara's first morning in Kijani



Amara's healing hut by the river - herbs drying under the roof, and the village waking below the canopy.

Yara is seventeen, half human and half Vey'kar. Yesterday her mother brought her to Kijani, the hidden village in the jungle. Today the village stops being a wonder - and starts being work.

CHAPTER 2

Yara woke before the light, in a village that was already awake.

That was the first surprise of the morning. She had lain awake half the night listening to Kijani sleep - the river, the night insects, someone coughing softly two shelters away, the torches ticking as they burned down - and she had assumed, without thinking about it, that dawn would bring the village to life all at once, the way a camp wakes.

It did not. Kijani did not wake. It simply continued, quieter people handing the dark over to louder ones. The night watch came down from the trees with their spears over their shoulders. The fire in the clearing, which had never quite gone out, was coaxed up again by an old woman who spoke to it under her breath. Somewhere, a child was already complaining, at length and with feeling, about being washed.

Yara lay on her mat in the corner of her mother's hut, her hands folded tight across her stomach, and listened, and tried the sentence again. *My home.* It still did not fit. It sat in her mouth like a word in a language she was learning - she knew what it meant, she just could not say it naturally yet. Part of her wanted it to fit so badly it hurt. Another part was still braced, waiting to be told this was only a visit, that she did not really belong here either.

Her father's name was still in the bottom of the pack beside her, carved into bone.

She had put it back exactly where she had found it, the way her mother had told her. She had not promised not to think about it - and she had thought of little else, turning the name over and over in the dark, hoping for an answer and angry, underneath the hope, that she had to hope at all.

Oya was already gone.

Her mat was rolled. Her knife was gone from its peg by the door. Through the woven wall Yara could hear the particular, unhurried sounds of heavy work being done well - timber, rope, voices calling measurements - and when she ducked out into the grey morning she saw why. Her mother was up in the frame of the half-built shelter, the one that had stood open like ribs yesterday, hauling on a rope with two builders while a third guided the beam home.

Oya did not wave. Her arms were braced on the rope, her markings steady and dim with the effort, and she nodded once, the way she nodded at everyone working, and called down, "Amara first."

"I know," Yara said, rubbing the sleep from one eye and trying to sound as if she had been awake for hours.

"Before food?" she asked, hopeful, her hand pressed flat to her empty stomach.

Yara's stomach answered that for her, loudly. From the tree above, somebody laughed, kindly. Oya's mouth did the thing it did instead of smiling in public. For a heartbeat her gaze stayed on Yara longer than a worker's nod required, her hand tightening on the rope - a mother's worry, and something heavier under it, guilt perhaps, quickly mastered and put away before anyone above or below could name it. "Amara will feed you," she said. "She feeds everyone she is about to scold. It is her custom."

The healing hut stood by the river at the edge of the clearing, and it announced itself before Yara reached it: bitter green herbs, woodsmoke, hot water, and underneath it all the clean smell of the river over stone. Leaves hung drying under the roof. Pots sat in a row so straight it looked like a rule. Amara was outside crushing something in a stone bowl, and she did not look up.

"You are late," she said, without looking up, the pestle never pausing in her hand, her voice dry as the herbs above her.

"The sun is not up." Yara folded her arms, chin up, certain of that much at least.

"Then you are early, and I am wrong." Amara set the bowl down with a small, amused breath through her nose, her markings giving one brief, warm flicker. "It happens once a year. Sit."

Amara's hands found the truth faster than Yara could arrange her face to hide it.

"Shoulder," the healer said, pressing two fingers into the muscle until Yara hissed and caught her breath, her shoulders hunching up toward her ears. "You carried that pack wrong all morning and said nothing. And the leg - " she turned Yara's left ankle with brisk, impersonal thoroughness, " - is tight, not injured, which means you favour it out of habit, which means one day you will turn on it in a real run and it will remind you of this conversation. Habits are injuries you schedule for later, child. I do not allow them in my hut."

She made a paste that smelled like pepper and river mud and worked it into Yara's shoulder without a shred of sympathy, talking while she worked.

"Zola will tell you that healing is what happens after the interesting part," Amara said, her thumbs never easing off, her tone fond and exasperated at once. "Zola is seventeen and immortal, like all of you. But hear me. A hunter who cannot read her own body will misread everything else. Pain is information. Tiredness is information. Now - " she sat back on her heels, " - your markings."

Yara looked down, wishing the ground would oblige her and open. Her arms, traitorous as ever, had brightened under the healer's scolding - a faint blue shimmer under the skin, nothing next to a full Vey'kar's glow, and hers to hide all the same. Amara watched it without surprise. She had plainly seen this coming before Yara had, and she waited, unhurried, the way someone waits who already knows how a lesson ends.

"Make them dim," Amara said. She set the paste aside and waited, hands loose in her lap, perfectly calm, as if she had all morning.

"I cannot just - " Yara broke off, flustered, and felt her face heat as the shimmer brightened again, giving her away.

Amara's voice softened, just a fraction. "You flare when you are flustered because you hold your breath like a girl caught stealing fruit. Breathe out. Long, through the nose. Again. You are not pushing the light down, Yara. You are putting down the feeling that feeds it."

It took four tries.

The first tries failed because her mind would not be still - she kept listening for judgment, kept bracing for failure. On the fourth, with the river loud in her ears and Amara counting her breaths in that flat, unimpressed voice, Yara felt it happen - not a switch, a settling. The shimmer on her arms sank the way embers sink when the fire stops being fed. It left her oddly calm, and a little annoyed that it had worked, because now she would have to do it every time.

"There," Amara said, with a short nod, satisfaction kept firmly under her usual flat tone. "That is the first true thing Kijani will teach you, and Zola cannot teach it, because Zola has the self-control of a falling branch. Control is not a gift, princess. It is a practice. Like everything else here."

Then she did feed her, as Oya had promised - a bowl of something hot and savoury, eaten sitting on the hut's low step, looking out at the river coming bright with the first real light.

"Your father sat on a step just like this one," Amara said, in the tone of a woman mentioning the weather, though her hands went still around the bowl and her gaze drifted to the step.

Yara stopped chewing. The bowl sat forgotten in her hands. Hope rose in her so fast and so painfully that she was afraid to move, afraid any small motion would scare this story away the way every other one had been taken from her.

"The first time he came to my hut - in the old place, before Kijani - he had put a thorn through his hand trying to help with a shelter, and he was determined to be brave about it, and he was very bad at being brave. He sat on that step and bled into his breakfast and told me, very seriously, that human healers charged money for this. Money. As if a thorn cared." Her eyes were on the river, and a real smile softened her face, there and gone. "He laughed at himself louder than anyone. That is a rare thing, in any people."

"Amara," Yara said carefully, her hands clasped tight in her lap to keep them still. "What happened to him?"

The healer was quiet long enough for the river to say several things. Her fingers turned the empty bowl slowly in her hands, her eyes not on Yara at all. She knew exactly how much she was holding back, and what it cost the girl to hear only part of it - that knowing was in the careful way she finally chose her words.

"He made me a promise, once," Amara said at last, her voice low, her markings dimming down to almost nothing. "On that step. And then he asked one of me." She stood up, and took Yara's empty bowl, and the moment closed like a door being shut gently - by someone who knows exactly how much noise a door makes. "When your mother is ready for the rest of that story, she will tell it. She keeps it the way she keeps that charm, child. Not because it is nothing. Because it is not nothing."

Yara's heart was going so hard her markings lit through all of Amara's good work. She wanted to demand the rest at once - and under the anger was a thin, stubborn hope: that a promise meant her father had meant to come back. She breathed out, long, through her nose, the way she had just been taught, and watched them sink again - and hated, and loved, that it worked.

She was still sitting there, holding a promise with no words in it, when a shadow fell across the step and a voice said, with enormous satisfaction, "Found you. That is one. We have not even started and I am winning." Zola's markings were bright with triumph, her grin wider still.

Zola stood over her with a coil of rope on one shoulder, a short spear in her hand, and the expression of a general who has waited months for an army of one. She had clearly been waiting within earshot, impatient down to her toes, and her impatience was its own kind of loyalty - she had claimed Yara's whole day before anyone else could.

"The list," Zola said, counting each item off on her fingers, bouncing lightly on the balls of her feet, "is as follows. Tracking. Climbing. Cloak work. Spear. River crossing, if there is time, and there will not be, because you are slow. Your healer has had you long enough. Mentors before trackers, fine - but trackers before breakfast is over, princess. Up." She jerked her chin toward the clearing, already turning to go.

The tracking went badly, which Zola said was the correct way for tracking to go the first time.

She had walked a trail out of the clearing at dawn and hidden three carved markers along it. Yara had to follow by scent and sign alone and bring them back. It sounded simple - until she reached the river path, where the damp had flattened every scent into wet earth, and Zola's footprints simply stopped, because Zola had walked the last stretch in the shallow edge of the river itself.

"You are allowed to do that?" Yara called, to the jungle in general, hands cupped around her mouth, half laughing and half furious.

"Prey does not ask permission," the jungle answered, from somewhere in the branches, in Zola's voice, smug and delighted and giving nothing away.

Yara stood in the wet ferns with mud on her knees, feeling foolish and hot with frustration, and made herself stop, breathe, and think instead of simply pushing harder. She found two markers. The second took her in a humiliating circle through ferns she would have sworn she had already searched. The third she did not find at all, and when Zola dropped out of a tree holding it, grinning, Yara's markings flared so bright that Zola pointed at them, her own grin fading into something almost kind, and said, "And that is how the prey finds *you*, princess. Breathe. The healer's trick. Use it." Yara dragged in a breath, cheeks burning, and made herself breathe out slowly.

Climbing went better. Yara was lighter than a full Vey'kar and she was quick, and for one shining minute, halfway up the great tree to the highest shelter, the bark rough under her palms and the ground falling away below her, she let herself enjoy being good at something in front of witnesses. Zola climbed below her the whole way - close enough to catch her, far enough to let her believe, kindly, that she might not need catching.

Then came the cloak.

The light-weave cloak bent the light around its wearer the way heat bends the air above hot stone - if the wearer could hold it.

Yara could hold it for about as long as she could hold her breath, on a good day, standing still, thinking about nothing. Zola's version of cloak work involved walking the length of the training ground, at the edge of the clearing, while Zola threw small soft fruits at the shimmer where she thought Yara was.

The first fruit missed. The second missed. Yara, moving slow as mist, began - unwisely - to feel proud.

"Your left side is showing," said a voice from the shade by the training ground, dry as old leaves. Jabari stood with his arms folded, utterly still, his own markings barely lit - control made visible. "And your feet are not blurred at all. A hunter who gleams at the edges is a story prey tells its children."

Jabari. Shame went through Yara hot and immediate, brightening every edge she had just failed to hide. He had been standing there long enough to see the best of the attempt and all of its failure, and he had said nothing until speaking would teach the most.

His disapproval, when it came, was aimed at the lesson and not at her worth - though it took Yara a long, burning moment to feel the difference. The cloak fell off her like water. All of her, edges, feet and everything, stood in the open in the morning light with a soft fruit bursting, mercifully wide, against the tree behind her - and Zola, who had thrown it, looked at Jabari and then very carefully did not laugh, which was worse.

"Elder," Zola said quickly, straightening, the fruit in her hand forgotten, all her mischief gone in an instant.

"Tracker," Jabari said, with a curt nod. "You teach her to hide. Good. When she can hide, teach her the rest." He looked at Yara for a moment, in that level, wintry way he had, as if he were reading weather far away. "Again," he said, quieter, and turned and walked off - not unkindly, which somehow left Yara more determined than any scolding would have.

"He stayed to watch," Zola whispered, amazed, crouching beside her to pick up the fruit, her eyes still wide. "Princess. He never stays."

In the afternoon, Yara worked.

Nobody had ordered her to. That was the point of it, though she only understood that afterwards. The beam her mother had hauled up at dawn was in place, and the half-built shelter needed hands - lashing, weaving, carrying - and the family building it looked at the princess standing in front of them with her sleeves pushed up, and after one careful moment, the father handed her a bundle of woven panels and pointed where they went, exactly as he would have pointed for anyone.

It was hot, repetitive, blister-raising work, and it was the best part of the day. For the length of that wall she was not a princess being watched, or a stranger being judged - she was simply a pair of hands that were needed, passing panels up in rhythm with the others, and that plain belonging settled deep in her chest. Her shoulder complained and then, warmed and used, stopped complaining the way Amara had said a cared-for body would. The family's smallest child followed her back and forth carrying one leaf at a time, with tremendous ceremony, and gravely accepted her thanks every time.

By the time the light went gold, the shelter had a wall it had not had that morning, and Yara had a blister, sawdust in her braids, and the family's mother's flat, approving nod - which she carried back to the fire that night like a hunt band.

Oya heard the whole day over the food, saying little, the way she listened to reports. In the firelight, with her guard lowered a fraction she would never have allowed in daylight, she looked tired in a way Yara had rarely been allowed to see - a leader carrying the worry of the whole village, and a mother carrying one girl's unanswered questions on top of it. But when Yara told her about Amara's step, and the promise with no words in it, her mother's hands went still on her bowl, her markings flickered once and then steadied, and her face did something complicated and then was still.

"She told you more than I would have," Oya said at last, her voice low, not looking up from the fire. "Remember it anyway."

End of Chapter 2

That night, Jabari stopped beside the fire on his way to his shelter, his markings dim and even in the firelight, and said, to no one in particular and to Yara entirely, "Dawn. The training ground. We will see what the healer's breathing is worth." Then he went on into the dark, and Zola looked at Yara across the flames and mouthed, *He never stays* - and underneath the words, underneath the whole long day, Yara lay awake in the corner of her mother's hut with her hand resting, without quite deciding to, on the bottom of the pack.

She lay awake listening to her mother's breathing across the hut, afraid of Jabari's dawn test and, underneath the fear, quietly determined not to shame herself at it. She had failed in front of him once today. She did not intend to spend tomorrow the same way. The bone charm was warm. Charms were warm when they rested near a hunter. But as Yara's fingers closed around it in the dark, she felt it - once, faint as a second heartbeat - hum.

Next: Chapter 3 - Jabari's dawn test on the training ground, the first hunt beyond the clearing, and what Yara's senses find in the jungle that should not be there.

Book plan: 20 chapters, about 250 pages - Act 1 is Chapters 1-5, Act 2 is Chapters 6-14, Act 3 is Chapters 15-20.